

St. Louis Metro Adult Education Career Pathway Analysis

Scope and executive conclusions

This analysis is designed for an adult education provider serving **GED/HSE and ESL learners in the St. Louis metropolitan labor market**, with particular attention to St. Louis City and County, St. Charles, Jefferson and Franklin counties in Missouri and St. Clair and Madison counties in Illinois. Missouri's regional labor-market projections generally treat Franklin, Jefferson, St. Charles, St. Louis City and St. Louis County as an integrated St. Louis labor market; Southwestern Illinois workforce planning likewise treats the Metro East as part of the larger cross-river economy. ¹

The evidence points to four especially strong pathway families for adult education over the next three to five years:

1. **Healthcare support**, particularly patient care technician/CNA and medical assistant.
2. **Transportation and logistics**, especially CDL plus warehouse/logistics preparation.
3. **Advanced manufacturing**, beginning with production/assembly and progressing to welding, CNC machining or industrial maintenance.
4. **Construction and building systems**, using pre-apprenticeship as the bridge to union apprenticeship and, for a shorter college route, HVAC/refrigeration.

Biotechnology/life sciences is an important St. Louis emerging sector, but I would treat it as a second-stage pathway rather than a first-line IET for the broad GED/HSE/ESL population. The regional Illinois WIOA plan explicitly identifies biotechnology as an emerging cluster on the Missouri side, and STLCC has created a two-semester Life Science Lab Assistant bridge; however, laboratory documentation, science vocabulary, precision measurement and postsecondary reading requirements create a noticeably higher academic and English threshold than CNA/PCT, warehouse, construction pre-apprenticeship or entry production. ²

Two sectors merit caution despite substantial hiring volume. **Food service/hospitality** creates many openings but has weaker wage progression: Southwestern Illinois projects 4,331 annual replacement openings in food preparation/serving but reports a median annual salary of only \$29,070 for that occupational group. **Entry-level IT** remains a valuable longer-term option, but current regional workforce planning places many of its better-paying openings at associate-degree or higher skill levels, while recent Missouri IT postings emphasize specialized software skills such as AWS, Python and SQL. ³

Data freshness

There is an important data-vintage issue. Missouri's [MERIC Occupational Projections portal](#) now hosts the **2024–2034 projection cycle**, while the most accessible published St. Louis short-term openings table is **2023–2025** and several local workforce analyses still reproduce the previous **2020–2030** regional

projections. Southwestern Illinois' current **2024–2028 Regional WIOA Plan**, published in February 2024, relies principally on **2022–2030 IDES projections**. Illinois' [OEWS wage page](#), however, is current through **2025 annual data** and provides entry, median and experienced wages for the Illinois portion of the St. Louis MSA. ⁴

For program planning, I therefore place more weight on the **direction of demand across multiple sources**—projections, current job postings, employer concentration and training infrastructure—than on any single forecast percentage.

Growing industries in the St. Louis labor market

Industry / cluster	Local evidence for the next three to five years	Adult-learner implications
Health care and social assistance	Missouri reported Health Care and Social Assistance as the industry with the most online job postings statewide in April–June 2026. Southwestern Illinois expects health care/social assistance to add the second-largest number of net jobs after transportation/warehousing, and nursing assistants are the top certificate/license-level occupation by projected openings in that region. ⁵	Very strong because the region has multiple short credentials, employer-sponsored training and clear ladders from CNA/PCT to LPN/RN. The chief barriers are clinical communication, background screening, shift work and healthcare documentation.
Transportation, distribution and logistics	Southwestern Illinois projects Transportation & Warehousing to outpace all other sectors in payroll-job and percentage growth through 2030; transportation and warehousing also had a location quotient above 1.5 in 2022. Transportation/material-moving occupations account for an estimated 352 annual growth openings and 4,054 replacement openings in the regional plan. In Missouri, heavy/tractor-trailer driver postings rose 104% year over year in June 2026 , after several months of increases. ³	Warehouse work can be an almost immediate on-ramp; CDL can turn that pathway into substantially higher earnings in four to eight weeks. CDL is less accessible to beginning ESL learners because English proficiency is a federal driver qualification and is actively enforced.
Manufacturing, aerospace and industrial technology	Manufacturing is one of Southwestern Illinois' designated emerging in-demand clusters and is projected to add jobs through 2030. On the Missouri side, St. Louis recorded 1,620 manufacturing postings in August 2024, and the region has large aerospace, automotive and advanced-manufacturing employers. Missouri's 2025 average wage for welders was \$55,470. ⁶	Excellent fit for contextualized math, measurement, workplace English and digital skills. Entry production can lead to welding, CNC, industrial maintenance and employer apprenticeships.

Industry / cluster	Local evidence for the next three to five years	Adult-learner implications
Construction and building systems	Missouri workforce research continues to identify construction and installation/maintenance/repair among areas with significant labor gaps. Southwestern Illinois classifies construction as “maturing” rather than high-growth, but explicitly says employment is not expected to drop sharply; the region also prioritizes Registered Apprenticeship and work-based learning. ⁷	Particularly attractive because apprentices can earn while learning . Math, transportation, drug screening and reliable attendance are larger barriers than formal academic credentials. HVAC adds a short college credential and EPA certification route.
Biotechnology and life sciences	The Southwestern Illinois WIOA plan specifically identifies biotechnology on the Missouri side of the St. Louis MSA as an emerging cluster. STLCC has a two-semester Life Science Lab Assistant certificate designed for research/manufacturing lab work and as a bridge into biotechnology/STEM degrees. ²	Promising for higher-level HSE and ESL learners, especially as a bridge-to-college pathway, but less suitable for very low English or numeracy levels.
Aviation/aerospace	Aviation is a targeted Southwestern Illinois cluster, while STLCC and Boeing now operate a 15-week Assembly Mechanic Apprenticeship for Boeing employees covering structures, electrical, mechanical and composites. ⁸	Strong advancement potential but best approached through manufacturing fundamentals and employer referral rather than as a stand-alone open-enrollment adult-ed credential.
Information technology	IT is an in-demand Southwestern Illinois cluster; however, the regional plan identifies computer user support specialist among associate-degree-level occupations, while Missouri’s 2025 IT postings increasingly request specific cloud, programming and database skills. ³	Worth retaining as a digital-literacy-to-IT bridge for stronger learners, but not as attractive as healthcare, logistics, trades or manufacturing for a broad entry-level GED/ESL cohort.

The **best evidence of durable demand is where growth and replacement needs overlap**. Healthcare has both demographic-driven growth and turnover. Transportation has unusually strong growth on the Illinois side plus replacement needs on both sides of the river. Manufacturing has employer concentration plus shortages in production and skilled technical occupations. Construction may grow more slowly, but apprenticeship retirements and replacement hiring make it a viable career pathway despite a less aggressive sector growth forecast. ⁹

Entry roles and common hiring requirements

The English classifications below—**foundational-to-working, working, and technical/regulated**—are program-design judgments, not employer-mandated CASAS, TABE or CEFR scores. They indicate how much reading, listening, speaking and documentation the job is likely to demand. Southwestern Illinois employers

identify active listening, reading comprehension, critical thinking, service orientation and social perceptiveness as important cross-sector skills. ¹⁰

Entry role	Credential / license	Screening and other hiring requirements	Baseline skills	English expectation	Digital skill need
Nursing assistant / patient care technician	In Missouri, CNA training ordinarily involves a DHSS-approved pathway with 75 classroom hours plus 100 supervised on-the-job/clinical hours and competency testing. STLCC's BJC PCT pathway meets Missouri requirements for unlicensed assistive personnel and can position employed graduates to challenge the CNA examination. ¹¹	Healthcare employers and clinical programs commonly use criminal-background and health/drug screening. Illinois explicitly requires a criminal-background process for nurse aides; SWIC requires the check before enrollment. ¹²	Patient safety, infection control, basic arithmetic, vital signs, body mechanics, active listening and customer service.	Working to moderately high. Learners must understand safety directions, communicate symptoms and care needs, and document accurately.	Moderate: EHR/charting, patient identifiers, basic computer log-in, secure messaging and sometimes barcode/device workflows.

Entry role	Credential / license	Screening and other hiring requirements	Baseline skills	English expectation	Digital skill need
Medical assistant	Certification is frequently preferred. STLCC's current employer-linked program prepares for CCMA and BLS credentials. 13	Employer/clinical-site background and drug screening are common; immunization/health documentation may be required by clinical partners.	Medical vocabulary, vital signs, basic clinical procedures, scheduling, customer service, basic medication/math concepts.	Moderately high. More telephone, patient instruction and written documentation than many CNA/PCT jobs.	Moderate-high: EHR, appointment scheduling, patient portals, scanning, data entry and electronic communication.
Warehouse/material mover, stocker or order filler	Usually no occupational license. Forklift certification may be employer-provided or preferred depending on the assignment.	HS/HSE is preferred by many employers but some jobs accept no formal credential. Safety-sensitive employers may require drug/background screening; lifting, standing and shift availability are common.	Counting, labels/SKUs, weights, basic arithmetic, following pick/pack instructions and safe material handling.	Foundational-to-working. Safety vocabulary and accurate label/location reading matter more than advanced writing.	Low-moderate: RF/barcode scanners, handheld devices, clock-in systems and basic warehouse-management screens.

Entry role	Credential / license	Screening and other hiring requirements	Baseline skills	English expectation	Digital skill need
CDL-A / CDL-B driver	Commercial learner permit, Entry-Level Driver Training when applicable, CDL skills test and DOT medical qualification. First-time Class A/B drivers and first H/P/S endorsements are subject to federal ELDT rules. ¹⁴	Driving-record review, DOT medical exam and federal drug/alcohol testing are central barriers. HAZMAT adds a TSA security threat/ background assessment. STLCC requires a valid license, acceptable recent MVR and the appropriate CLP before its driving phase. ¹⁵	Vehicle inspection, reading gauges, basic arithmetic, route/time management, safety judgment and record keeping.	Technical/ regulated. Federal law requires sufficient English to converse with the public, understand English traffic signs/signals, respond to officials and complete reports/records. Enforcement of this rule was strengthened beginning in 2025 and remains active in 2026. ¹⁶	Moderate: ELD, GPS/navigation, electronic inspection/log systems and dispatch apps.
Production / assembly technician	Frequently no external license for entry production. OSHA/safety credentials or employer-specific manufacturing credentials can strengthen a candidate. Boeing's current apprenticeship supplies company-specific assembly training. ¹⁷	Drug/ background screening and physical requirements vary by employer; aerospace and other regulated environments can be more stringent. Shift flexibility is often valuable.	Measurement, fractions/ decimals, torque/tool use, quality checks, work instructions, safety and dependable attendance.	Working. Technical vocabulary and the ability to follow written work instructions matter.	Moderate: digital work orders, HMIs, quality entry, tablets and electronic timekeeping.

Entry role	Credential / license	Screening and other hiring requirements	Baseline skills	English expectation	Digital skill need
Welder	Missouri does not use one universal entry license for all welders; employers hire to process/ position qualifications and may prefer recognized credentials. STLCC training includes multiple welding processes and OSHA 10 content; SWIC follows AWS Level I/II-aligned standards. ¹⁸	Employer weld test is common; drug/ background screening varies. PPE, physical stamina and safety compliance are essential.	Fractions/ decimals, measurement, blueprint/ symbol reading, visual quality inspection and shop safety.	Working. Technical reading is more important than extensive customer conversation.	Low-moderate: electronic drawings, work orders and increasingly computerized/ robotic welding equipment.
CNC operator / entry machinist	Industry certification such as NIMS can strengthen employability. STLCC's 17-credit Precision Machining certificate prepares students for up to seven NIMS Level I credentials. ¹⁹	Employer screening varies. Safety, precision, attendance and the ability to pass practical skills assessments are common priorities.	Strong measurement, decimals/ fractions, tolerances, shop math, blueprint reading and quality control.	Working to technical. Learners must accurately interpret specifications and setup instructions.	Moderate-high: CNC controller interfaces, digital readouts, basic machine programming concepts and electronic quality records.

Entry role	Credential / license	Screening and other hiring requirements	Baseline skills	English expectation	Digital skill need
Construction pre-apprentice / registered apprentice	Initial pre-apprenticeship usually does not require a trade license; the goal is placement into a registered union or employer apprenticeship. Missouri Works Initiative's Building Union Diversity/ Apprenticeship Ready model is a no-cost local bridge. ²⁰	Typical trade entry barriers include age 18+, work authorization, drug screening, reliable transportation and math/ aptitude testing. Local Pipefitters/ Plumbers/ HVAC intake requires HS diploma/ equivalent, driver's license, math testing, drug test and physical. ²¹	Measurement, fractions, basic algebra/ geometry, tool identification, safety, physical endurance and teamwork.	Working. Safety communication and trade vocabulary are essential; exact demands vary by craft.	Low-moderate: mobile timekeeping, plans/drawings, jobsite communication and increasingly BIM/digital documentation.
HVAC helper / technician	Anyone who services equipment in ways that can release regulated refrigerants must hold EPA Section 608 certification ; the certification does not expire. STLCC's short HVAC certificate is specifically designed to prepare for Section 608. ²²	A valid driver's license/ acceptable driving record is frequently important for field-service jobs; drug/ background checks depend on employer/ client sites.	Basic electrical concepts, measurement, troubleshooting, temperatures/ pressures, mechanical reasoning and safety.	Working to technical. Service technicians also need customer-facing communication.	Moderate: digital multimeters/ gauges, diagnostic equipment, mobile work-order and scheduling applications.

A particularly important distinction for ESL programming is that **CDL English is not merely an employer preference**. Under 49 CFR §391.11(b)(2), a driver must be able to read and speak English sufficiently for public interaction, road signs, official inquiries and required records. FMCSA's enforcement posture changed materially in 2025, making a targeted **CDL workplace-English bridge** much more important than it would have appeared several years ago. ²³

Healthcare also warrants a higher English threshold than its short training duration might suggest. A nine-week PCT course is academically accessible, but safe patient communication and electronic documentation make this a poor candidate for “credential first, English later.” A co-taught or tightly aligned healthcare-ESL model is preferable.

Local training and credential map

Costs below are the **published 2026 figures where available**. When a provider does not publicly itemize a current total, I say so rather than extrapolating. College tuition totals generally exclude books, tools, uniforms, screening, certification testing and other fees unless noted.

Provider / program	Cost	Duration and cadence	Modality / schedule	Location	Admission and prerequisites
STLCC Patient Care Technician / BJC	Employer/funding-supported for selected trainees; exact participant out-of-pocket amount depends on the BJC arrangement. Employment commitment may apply. ²⁴	9 weeks. A current cohort begins Sept. 21, 2026. ²⁵	Hybrid. First five weeks generally M–F, about 8:30 a.m.–3:30 p.m., plus online work; clinical phase is four weeks of three 12-hour shifts and may include evenings/weekends. ²⁵	Florissant Valley, Forest Park and William J. Harrison Education Center; clinicals through BJC. ²⁵	Generally 18+, HS diploma/ HSE and selection through BJC's PCT Training hiring process. No prior patient-care experience is required; interpersonal/customer-service skills are emphasized. ²⁴

Provider / program	Cost	Duration and cadence	Modality / schedule	Location	Admission and prerequisites
STLCC Medical Assistant	Employer funded for selected participants; current model carries a two-year employment commitment with partner employers. ¹³	16 weeks , employer-cohort cadence. ¹³	Hybrid; intensive accelerated format.	Florissant Valley and Forest Park; partner employers include BJC Medical Group and St. Luke's Medical Group. ¹³	Employer selection/hiring process; prepares for CCMA and BLS credentials. Exact screening is governed by employer and clinical requirements. ¹³
SWIC Nurse Assistant	For 2026–27, seven-credit in-district tuition is approximately \$1,015 at \$145/credit; SWIC publishes estimated direct CNA costs of about \$1,478 , with an \$85 state exam identified separately. Eligible Adult Education vocational students may receive training free. ²⁶	One course/one semester; sections are offered in 16-week and accelerated 6-week formats, with multiple-campus offerings each semester. ²⁷	In-person lecture/lab plus required clinical.	Belleville/Granite City and other SWIC service-area sites depending on section.	IDPH-approved curriculum; criminal-background check before enrollment/clinical participation and required attendance. ²⁸

Provider / program	Cost	Duration and cadence	Modality / schedule	Location	Admission and prerequisites
SWIC Adult Education Vocational Classes	Free to qualified students through grant funding. ²⁹	Varies by credential. Current menu includes CNA, Community Health Worker, CNC Precision Machining and Pharmacy Technician. ²⁹	Schedule/ location vary by cohort.	SWIC district / Metro East.	Designed for eligible adult-education participants; the page specifically identifies eligibility tied to Illinois DHS services and/or ESL populations. This is one of the strongest ready-made IET/co-enrollment partners for an ESL program. ²⁹
St. Charles Community College CNA	SCC's web materials separately identify \$350 for the clinical course/ component , but do not provide a sufficiently clear current all-in total to quote safely; confirm tuition, lab, screening and exam costs with SCC before referral. ³⁰	Classroom/lab plus 100 hours of clinical training ; schedule options vary by term. ³⁰	Online/ classroom content plus in-person skills lab and clinical; clinical can meet four times per week.	Center for Healthy Living, Dardenne Creek Campus, and clinical sites.	Generally 18+ for the course; urine drug screen is required before clinical. ³⁰

Provider / program	Cost	Duration and cadence	Modality / schedule	Location	Admission and prerequisites
St. Charles Community College Medical Assisting	SCC's Fall 2026 example lists approximately \$2,325 for the first 15-credit semester for an in-district student; second-semester and credential costs are additional. ³¹	Two semesters. ³¹	Primarily scheduled college coursework; current sections include in-person and online components depending on course.	Cottleville / St. Charles County.	College admission plus program/course prerequisites; health-program requirements apply. ³¹
STLCC CDL-A and CDL-B	CDL-A \$6,500 plus about \$175 DOT physical/medical cost; CDL-B \$3,500 plus approximately \$175. HAZMAT course \$129. These short noncredit programs are not Pell-funded, although other need-based/workforce funding may be available. ³²	CDL-A day: 4 weeks; night: 5 weeks. Current Fall 2026 starts include Aug. 31, Oct. 5 and Nov. 2/9 depending schedule. CDL-B: 7 training days, with an Oct. 5, 2026 example start. ³³	CDL-A day approximately M–F 7 a.m.–3:30 p.m.; night approximately 4–10 p.m. CDL-B daytime.	Forest Park's Transportation Education Center, 5600 Oakland Ave., St. Louis. ³⁴	Valid driver license, information session/application, acceptable MVR and appropriate CLP; Class A CLP includes general knowledge, air brakes and combination vehicles. Age 18 permits intrastate operation; federal/interstate requirements may be more restrictive. ³⁵

Provider / program	Cost	Duration and cadence	Modality / schedule	Location	Admission and prerequisites
Lewis and Clark Community College Truck Driver Training	Current program page does not publish a dependable all-in 2026 price; WIOA and workforce funding should be screened before enrollment.	Class A: 8–16 weeks; Class B: 4 weeks. ³⁶	Morning-only and full-day options are available. ³⁶	Godfrey/Madison County service area.	Designed to prepare students for Illinois Class A or B CDL testing; licensing/medical prerequisites apply. ³⁶
STLCC Welding Technology	16-credit Certificate of Specialization: approximately \$2,032 in-district tuition at \$127/credit before fees/tools; 31-credit Certificate of Proficiency about \$3,937 before fees/tools. ³⁷	One or more semesters depending credential and course load; standard semester cadence.	Primarily hands-on, in person.	Florissant Valley.	Open college admission with course prerequisites. Curriculum includes multiple welding processes and OSHA 10/safety content. ³⁸
STLCC Precision Machining Technology	17 credits , approximately \$2,159 in-district tuition before fees/tools at \$127/credit. ³⁹	Generally completable in one to two semesters depending scheduling.	Hands-on/in person.	Florissant Valley.	College admission and course prerequisites; prepares for entry CNC/machining work and up to seven NIMS Level I credentials. ¹⁹

Provider / program	Cost	Duration and cadence	Modality / schedule	Location	Admission and prerequisites
STLCC HVAC Technician	7 credits , roughly \$889 in-district tuition before fees at \$127/credit. STLCC notes that financial aid is not available for this short certificate , making Fast Track/WIOA screening particularly important. ⁴⁰	Short certificate; semester-based.	In-person technical coursework.	Florissant Valley.	College admission/course prerequisites; designed to prepare learners for EPA Section 608 certification. ⁴¹
SWIC Welding Technology	2026–27 in-district tuition is \$145 per credit plus college fees; total depends on whether the learner chooses Basic, Advanced or Advanced Manufacturing certificate coursework. ⁴²	Semester-based, with several stackable certificate choices.	Predominantly hands-on; day/evening availability varies by term.	SWIC technical campuses, including the Metro East service area.	Beginner-accessible; curriculum includes SMAW, GMAW, FCAW, GTAW, robotic welding and CNC plasma and follows AWS Level I/II standards. ⁴³

Provider / program	Cost	Duration and cadence	Modality / schedule	Location	Admission and prerequisites
Boeing / STLCC Assembly Mechanic Apprenticeship	Participants are Boeing employees receiving pay and benefits during training rather than tuition-paying open-enrollment students. ⁴⁴	15 weeks; cohort/ employer driven.	Intensive hands-on employer apprenticeship training.	STLCC/Boeing St. Louis training environment.	As of 2026, this pathway is for existing Boeing employees , with four tracks: structures, electrical, mechanical and composites. Successful completion can lead to union-represented assembly mechanic work. ⁴⁴
Missouri Works Initiative Building Union Diversity / Apprenticeship Ready	No cost to the participant. ²⁰	About 5–6 weeks , cohort based.	In-person, intensive pre-apprenticeship.	St. Louis; training connects participants with multiple union trades.	Common requirements include age 18+, authorization to work and ability to pass a drug test; no previous construction experience is the point of the pre-apprenticeship model. Transportation assistance/ support is incorporated into the program model. ⁴⁵

Provider / program	Cost	Duration and cadence	Modality / schedule	Location	Admission and prerequisites
Mid-America Carpenters St. Louis Apprenticeship	Apprentices are paid employees and receive wage increases as they progress; training is apprenticeship-funded rather than conventional college tuition. ⁴⁶	Eight terms, approximately 4½ years , including about 6,000 job-site hours and 18 training units. ⁴⁶	Paid on-the-job training plus scheduled classroom/shop instruction.	St. Louis training center/job sites.	Intake is through the apprenticeship/union-contractor system; current application requirements should be verified at referral. ⁴⁶
St. Louis Pipefitter / Plumber / HVAC apprenticeship information	Current local information posts apprentice rates from approximately \$22.77 to \$43.01/hour , progressing to a journey-level rate of about \$50.60/hour . ⁴⁷	Multi-year registered apprenticeship; intake information is posted locally and applications are generally accepted on scheduled monthly dates.	Paid OJT plus apprenticeship classes.	St. Louis region.	HS diploma/ GED, age 18+, valid identification/ license, transcripts and aptitude/math expectations; the Local 562 process includes math testing, drug test and physical. ²¹

Additional nearby-county capacity

East Central College in Union is a useful Franklin County partner. Its Center for Workforce Development has offered CNA, welding, HVAC, manufacturing maintenance and logistics-related SkillUP training, and its current registered-apprenticeship operation says its apprenticeships typically last two to three years, can cover manufacturing, healthcare, logistics and other occupations, and award nationally recognized credentials. The college's current site confirms its Union location and active workforce programming. ⁴⁸

Jefferson College in Hillsboro is likewise strategically important for Jefferson County; its current program inventory includes HVAC and metal-fabrication technical credentials. Specific 2026 cohort prices and schedules should be confirmed directly rather than assumed from older catalogs. [Jefferson College program site](#) ⁴⁹

For higher-performing learners interested in life sciences, [STLCC Life Science Lab Assistant](#) is a **two-semester** certificate designed for laboratory work in life-science research/manufacturing and to bridge into

biotechnology and STEM degrees. ⁵⁰ [Lewis and Clark's Process Operations Technology](#) is another higher-skill Metro East option developed with Phillips 66 Wood River, with certificate/degree routes serving process and bioprocess industries. ⁵¹

Learner supports, funding and access

The St. Louis region has unusually good ingredients for **braided adult-education/workforce funding**, but learners should not be told that a credential is “free” until a workforce or financial-aid determination has actually been made. WIOA, SNAP E&T, Fast Track and institutional aid all have different eligibility and allowable-cost rules.

Support	Missouri side	Illinois / Metro East side
WIOA training	The SLATE Missouri Job Center provides free employment services and access to Adult/Dislocated Worker training, career and technical education, work experience and other workforce services. St. Louis County Workforce Development also operates WIOA training and employment services. ⁵²	SWIC WIOA Career Services states that eligible WIOA participants can complete an associate degree or certificate with training costs covered. Southwestern Illinois' workforce plan also emphasizes OJT, paid work experience and Registered Apprenticeship. ⁵³
Missouri Fast Track	STLCC Fast Track can combine with other aid so eligible adults in approved high-demand programs have tuition and fees covered; when other aid already covers tuition, up to \$500 may be available for education-related expenses. Eligible STLCC areas include HVAC, precision machining, truck driving and welding. St. Charles Community College also participates. ⁵⁴	Not applicable; Illinois uses different state/workforce grant structures.
Pell / FAFSA	Eligible undergraduate adults can receive Federal Pell Grants regardless of age if they meet financial and other federal eligibility rules and are enrolled in an eligible program. The maximum Pell award cited for 2026–27 is \$7,395 . Short noncredit training such as STLCC CDL is not automatically Pell eligible, so FAFSA/Pell should be treated as a program-by-program question. ⁵⁵	Same federal rules. SWIC's regional workforce plan specifically identifies FAFSA assistance as part of its transition services. ⁵⁶

Support	Missouri side	Illinois / Metro East side
SNAP E&T / SkillUP	Missouri's SkillUP system supports SNAP recipients with employment/training services. Current DSS material specifically says SkillUP coaches can assist with transportation costs, job-required items and career coaching , and the provider portal maintains transportation-expense and supportive-service processes. ⁵⁷	Illinois' SNAP Workforce Partnership provides SNAP-connected employment and training, subject to current eligibility/work requirements. SWIC's free Adult Education vocational model is especially useful for eligible Illinois DHS/ESL participants. ⁵⁸
Transportation	SkillUP can assist qualifying SNAP recipients with transportation expenses. BUD also incorporates transportation assistance in its apprenticeship-readiness model. ⁵⁹	SWIC provides eligible students bus/ MetroLink assistance; Lewis and Clark provides bus passes/tokens to eligible students. Madison County Employment and Training provides MCT passes to certain WIOA youth/ veteran customers for job-center, interview and initial employment transportation. ⁶⁰
Childcare	Availability is more fragmented; WIOA/ partner supportive-service eligibility should be checked at intake rather than assumed.	The regional WIOA plan says SWIC offers childcare assistance through Children's Home & Aid. Madison County WIOA may fund limited childcare for an employment/ training need, while LWIA 24 provides transportation and childcare case by case. ⁶⁰
Tutoring / academic help	STLCC provides tutoring and student-support services; its AEL program can remain the academic home while a learner transitions into occupational training. ⁶¹	SWIC students can use the Student Success Center, libraries and computer labs. Lewis and Clark provides tutoring through student-success centers, and its Adult Education operation provides transportation, case management and transition services. ⁶⁰
English / HSE support	STLCC Adult Education & Literacy offers free HSE preparation and ESL . Its separate English Language Programs page confirms free ESL from beginner Level 1 upward and distinguishes noncredit ESL from tuition-bearing college English for Multilingual Learners. ⁶²	SWIC's ESL-HEC and free vocational classes offer unusually direct connections between English-language education and CNA/other occupational training; its regional workforce plan explicitly embeds adult education in workforce-readiness strategy. ⁶³

Support	Missouri side	Illinois / Metro East side
Digital skills	SLATE and regional partners offer basic computer/job-readiness resources; STLCC's transition to college gives learners access to digital student systems and tutoring. ⁶⁴	The regional plan identifies Urban League computer courses and IMPACT CIL's individualized keyboarding, Word, PowerPoint, email, internet, résumé and job-search assistance. ⁶⁵

The Illinois side is especially notable for supportive services. The current regional WIOA plan says SWIC can provide bus/MetroLink passes, career training, FAFSA/transition assistance and childcare assistance, while Lewis and Clark can provide transportation, tutoring, financial assistance, case management and transition services. Madison County WIOA can use supportive funds for needs such as transportation, limited childcare, car repair, interview clothing and other reasonable employment/training barriers; St. Clair-area services can provide transportation and childcare case by case. ⁶⁰

For a St. Louis adult education operator, this argues strongly for **formal co-enrollment procedures rather than passive referral**. A learner entering CNA, welding or CDL should ideally have a workforce-funding screening, transportation plan, digital-readiness assessment and—where needed—English support resolved **before** occupational training begins.

Wages and advancement

"Starting wage" is difficult to standardize because employers vary by shift, union status and experience. Illinois' 2025 OEWS system now publishes **entry, median and experienced wages** for the Illinois portion of the St. Louis MSA in its downloadable workbook; that is the best source to refresh wage assumptions immediately before recruiting a cohort. ⁶⁶

The table below uses the freshest directly supportable local figures found in the public sources. Where the available number is an **average rather than a starting rate**, it is labeled accordingly.

Role	Local wage/demand evidence	Advancement path
Nursing assistant / PCT	MERIC's St. Louis 2023–25 short-term projections show roughly 1,686 annual openings for nursing assistants and an average annual wage of about \$36,673 . Southwestern Illinois also identifies nursing assistant as its leading certificate/license occupation by projected openings. ⁶⁷	PCT/CNA → senior PCT/CNA or specialty unit → LPN → RN . STLCC's LPN pathway can be completed in roughly two semesters; SWIC also offers a one-year practical-nursing certificate and CNA-to-PN progression opportunities. ⁶⁸

Role	Local wage/demand evidence	Advancement path
Medical assistant	The most recent St. Louis-specific BLS figure available on an easily accessible occupation table was \$40,530 mean annual wage in May 2023 ; use the current 2025 IDES MSA workbook for a current Illinois-side entry wage before setting cohort wage targets. ⁶⁹	MA → senior/lead MA → specialty clinic, care coordination or practice operations → LPN/RN or another allied-health credential.
Warehouse / material mover	MERIC's St. Louis 2023–25 table reports roughly 2,049 annual openings for hand laborers/freight/stock/material movers and an average annual wage around \$43,418 . ⁷⁰	Picker/material handler → forklift/order selector → inventory or shipping/receiving → lead → logistics coordinator/supervisor; CDL is a natural wage-upgrade credential.
CDL heavy truck driver	MERIC's St. Louis 2023–25 table reports about 1,437 annual openings and an average annual wage around \$59,193 ; Missouri postings for heavy/tractor-trailer drivers were also up 104% year over year in June 2026. ⁷¹	Class B/local delivery → Class A → regional/interstate → specialized tanker/HAZMAT or dedicated routes → trainer, dispatcher or fleet supervision.
Production / assembly	Current wages vary substantially by employer and shift. Manufacturing remains a designated regional demand cluster; Boeing's 15-week apprentice model offers paid employee training and a path to union-represented assembly mechanic work. ⁸	Production/assembly → skilled assembler → welding/CNC/industrial maintenance → lead, technician or supervisor.
Welder	Missouri's 2025 average annual wage was \$55,470 , according to MERIC's August 2026 occupational update. ⁷²	Entry welder → multi-process/structural welder → pipe or specialty welding → lead, inspector, robotic welding/operator or supervisor.
CNC operator / machinist	Current St. Louis entry rates should be pulled from MERIC/IDES OEWS immediately before cohort launch; the local training infrastructure supports movement into NIMS-certified precision machining. ⁷³	CNC operator → setup machinist → machinist → CNC programmer/process technician → lead/quality/manufacturing engineering technician.
Construction apprentice	The local pipefitter/plumber/HVAC pathway posts apprentice pay beginning around \$22.77/hour , increasing through approximately \$43.01 , with a journey-level rate around \$50.60/hour . Carpenters similarly receive wage increases and benefits as they advance through apprenticeship terms. ⁷⁴	Pre-apprentice → registered apprentice → journey worker → foreman → general foreman/superintendent or contractor.

Role	Local wage/demand evidence	Advancement path
HVAC technician	Wage varies by union/nonunion and service specialization. The strongest local high-wage progression is into pipefitter/HVAC apprenticeship, where the published journey rate is about \$50.60/hour. ⁴⁷	Helper → EPA-certified service technician → commercial HVAC/refrigeration or controls → senior tech/lead → union journey worker, estimator or service manager.

The wage evidence reinforces an important program-design point: **the shortest route is not always the best endpoint**. Warehouse, PCT and entry production are valuable primarily because they can be structured as **on-ramps to a second credential**. CDL, nursing progression, skilled welding/CNC and registered construction apprenticeships are where substantially stronger wage trajectories emerge. ⁷⁵

Recommended pathways for adult education program development

Healthcare support: PCT/CNA to LPN/RN

Overall assessment: strongest broad-access pathway.

Healthcare combines persistent hiring, short training, multiple local providers, employer-funded models and an unusually clear career ladder. Southwestern Illinois identifies nursing assistant as its highest-opening certificate/license occupation, while MERIC projects roughly 1,686 annual nursing-assistant openings in the Missouri St. Louis region in its 2023–25 short-term table. STLCC's nine-week BJC PCT and 16-week employer-funded MA programs create unusually direct employer connections, while SWIC adds a state-approved CNA program plus a free Adult Education vocational route for qualified learners. ⁷⁶

The principal risk for ESL learners is **underestimating language demand**. Patient safety, symptom communication, medical vocabulary and charting require stronger listening/speaking/reading than the credential's short duration suggests. Background checks, clinical screening and shift availability can also remove learners late in the process unless screened up front. ¹²

Most promising adult-education role: IET/contextualized healthcare instruction plus co-enrollment. A strong model would integrate medical vocabulary, body systems, measurement, charting language, patient-dialogue practice, digital/EHR simulations and HSE science/math with a CNA/PCT training partner. For learners below the occupational English threshold, run a short healthcare bridge first rather than placing them directly into clinical training. SWIC's ESL/Adult Education vocational structure is a particularly useful local model. ⁷⁷

Partner priority: STLCC/BJC on the Missouri side; SWIC on the Illinois side; SCC for St. Charles County; SLATE/County WIOA and SkillUP for funding/support.

Transportation and logistics: warehouse to CDL

Overall assessment: strongest wage-upgrade pathway, with a significant English barrier at the CDL stage.

Transportation and warehousing is the clearest growth story in Southwestern Illinois: it is projected to outpace every other sector in job and percentage growth, and transportation/material-moving occupations have both high growth and replacement openings. Missouri's latest job-posting trend is also favorable, with heavy-truck driver postings up 104% year over year in June 2026. Local training can be completed in as little as four to five weeks at STLCC for Class A or four to sixteen weeks through Lewis and Clark depending on license and schedule. ⁷⁸

This pathway can be sequenced effectively for adult learners:

warehouse/material handling → workplace English/digital/logistics skills → CDL permit preparation → CDL-A/B → HAZMAT or specialized driving.

Warehouse provides a low-credential first step while the learner builds English, earns income and prepares for the permit. The CDL stage is attractive financially, but it is no longer appropriate to treat limited English as something that can be compensated for simply by memorizing the written test. FMCSA requires operational English and has strengthened enforcement. ⁷⁹

Most promising adult-education role: CDL bridge + contextualized English/numeracy/digital instruction. The adult education program could provide CLP vocabulary, vehicle-inspection English, road-sign comprehension, oral responses to enforcement officials, log/report language, ELD practice and basic route/math instruction before referral to driving school. For beginning ESL learners, warehouse/logistics IET should precede CDL rather than forcing an early regulatory language barrier.

Partner priority: STLCC Transportation Education Center, Lewis and Clark, SLATE/St. Louis County workforce agencies, SkillUP and Illinois WIOA. Because STLCC's CDL-A tuition is \$6,500 and is not a conventional Pell-supported short program, funding navigation is a central—not peripheral—part of the pathway. ⁸⁰

Advanced manufacturing: production to welding, CNC or industrial maintenance

Overall assessment: strongest option for learners who prefer hands-on work and can build applied math.

Manufacturing is a regional target cluster, and St. Louis has a deep employer base in aerospace, automotive, metal fabrication and related production. Entry production often does not require a postsecondary credential, while STLCC and SWIC provide stackable welding and machining credentials. Boeing's 15-week paid employee apprenticeship demonstrates a particularly valuable local advancement mechanism from entry employment into skilled assembly. ⁸¹

The academic barrier is often **not traditional reading/writing; it is applied numeracy:** fractions, decimals, tolerances, measurement, blueprint interpretation and quality checks. That makes manufacturing unusually well suited to an adult-education IET because HSE mathematics can be taught through calipers, tape measures, production drawings and shop problems rather than through decontextualized worksheets.

Digital skills also deserve deliberate instruction. Modern entry production increasingly involves tablets, digital work instructions, HMIs, scanners and quality-entry systems; CNC adds a substantially higher digital/

technical threshold. STLCC's precision-machining certificate directly prepares for CNC operation and up to seven NIMS credentials. ¹⁹

Most promising adult-education role: manufacturing IET/bridge with contextualized math, workplace English and digital skills, followed by co-enrollment in welding/CNC or employer-based apprenticeship. A short "manufacturing fundamentals" bridge could teach measurement, fractions/decimals, blueprint vocabulary, safety, quality, basic computer work orders and employability skills before a learner chooses welding, CNC or maintenance.

Partner priority: STLCC Florissant Valley/Center for Workforce Innovation, SWIC welding/CNC, East Central College for Franklin County, workforce boards and manufacturing employers. Use Boeing as an advancement/referral partner for employees rather than portraying its current program as open enrollment. ⁸²

Construction and HVAC: pre-apprenticeship to registered apprenticeship

Overall assessment: strongest earn-and-learn pathway.

Construction does not have the same headline growth rate as healthcare or Metro East logistics, but it offers a feature the other pathways cannot match: **training itself can become paid employment**. Missouri Works Initiative's St. Louis Building Union Diversity/Apprenticeship Ready model is free and approximately five to six weeks, after which candidates can pursue registered apprenticeships. Mid-America Carpenters' local program combines about 6,000 job-site hours with formal instruction over roughly 4½ years, while local pipefitter/plumber/HVAC apprentices start around \$22.77/hour and progress through structured wage increases toward a journey rate around \$50.60/hour. ⁸³

The barriers are highly compatible with adult education intervention: applied math, drug-screen readiness, driver's license/transportation, reliable attendance, aptitude testing and workplace English. Formal college-level English is far less central than in healthcare or biotechnology. HVAC also offers a parallel short-college route through STLCC's seven-credit certificate and EPA Section 608 certification. ⁸⁴

Most promising adult-education role: pre-apprenticeship bridge and credential preparation, not duplication of trade training. Adult education should focus on fractions, measurement, algebra, reading plans, safety vocabulary, OSHA concepts, apprenticeship application/test preparation, digital jobsite skills and HSE completion, then hand the learner to BUD or a registered apprenticeship. For HVAC-bound learners, add EPA 608 technical vocabulary and exam preparation.

Partner priority: Missouri Works Initiative/BUD, Mid-America Carpenters, Local 562 and other St. Louis union apprenticeship programs, STLCC HVAC and WIOA supportive-service partners. Transportation planning should occur before referral because apprenticeship job sites can shift geographically.

Priority order for investment

Considering **demand, wage potential, credential time, accessibility, local training capacity, funding options, ESL feasibility and advancement**, I would rank the pathways this way:

Priority	Pathway	Why it scores well	Primary constraint
Highest	Healthcare support → LPN/RN	Very high openings; nine-week PCT and one-semester CNA options; employer-funded programs; free SWIC Adult Ed pathways; strong wage ladder; abundant partners. ⁸⁵	Clinical English, background/health screening, shift schedules.
Highest	Manufacturing → welding/CNC/maintenance	Multiple entry points; strong regional employer base; stackable short certificates; applied-math IET fit; Missouri welder average \$55,470 in 2025; aerospace advancement. ⁸⁶	Math/measurement, transportation to industrial sites, shift work.
High	Construction → registered apprenticeship/HVAC	Free pre-apprenticeship, paid learning, exceptional wage progression and no four-year degree requirement. ⁸⁷	Drug screening, driving/transportation, physical demands, competitive apprenticeship intake.
High	Warehouse/logistics → CDL	Metro East's strongest projected sector growth; very short CDL training; strong current driver demand and approximately \$59,193 local average wage in MERIC's short-term table. ⁸⁸	CDL cost, driving record/medical eligibility and federally enforced English requirement.

For a program that must choose only **two initial IET investments**, I would start with **healthcare support and manufacturing**. Both permit learners to enter at different English/HSE levels, both have multiple colleges and employers with whom to share training rather than building expensive occupational labs internally, and both offer stackable advancement. ⁸⁹

I would build **construction as a bridge/referral pathway** in partnership with BUD and the trades, where the adult education provider concentrates on math, HSE, English, digital readiness and apprenticeship testing rather than duplicating excellent existing trade instruction. ⁹⁰

Finally, I would develop **CDL/logistics as a specialized ESL-to-career pathway** rather than a general ESL referral. The recent federal English-proficiency enforcement environment makes a well-designed occupational-English component a genuine competitive advantage for both learners and training partners. ⁹¹

The most productive operating model across all four pathways is therefore **adult education as the bridge and integration layer**: screen out credential barriers early; contextualize HSE/ESL instruction to the occupation; teach the digital systems learners will encounter; co-enroll them with WIOA/SNAP E&T and the technical provider; solve transportation and childcare before training begins; and maintain instruction through the first credential and into the next step on the career ladder. The St. Louis region already has most of the occupational-training infrastructure required—the highest-value gap for an adult education provider is connecting that infrastructure to learners who are not yet linguistically, academically, digitally or financially ready to use it. ⁹²

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